> could not recognise a person whom he had well known before, if he had not seen him even for a day; but he perfectly understood the real meaning of our treaty with the king, and by it he knew that we had no right to take over the administration of the country.[73]

Long before Shah Shuja lost his patience with the interference of Macnaghten and Burnes in his internal affairs, Mullah Shakur was trying to resist British encroachment into the daily running of the country, while maintaining the appearance that Shuja was really running everything. ‘As long as Mullah Shakur was in office, the polite fiction was maintained that His Majesty did have some say in the affairs of the kingdom and the army,’ wrote Mohammad Husain Herati.

> For example, if the price of wheat was fixed at a particular rate, any trader who flouted the rules would be punished by Mullah Shakur in his role as assistant governor of Kabul – but whenever Alexander Burnes sent his chaprasi messenger to protest that the trader in question was under his protection, the offender would be released. By such means, Mullah Shakur attempted to maintain the appearance of the legitimacy of the government. But Burnes and Macnaghten did not like to be contradicted in any way, nor to pay attention to the intricacies of government, and day by day they grew more hostile to the Mullah.[74]

These were not the only things that undermined the popularity and effectiveness of Shah Shuja’s government as spring turned to summer in 1840. Many were now complaining of Shuja’s distant style, which formed a sharp contrast with the consciously egalitarian approach of Dost Mohammad. It had long been a pattern with Shuja that the more he felt his status diminished, the more he wished to make public demonstrations of his rank. So it was in 1840, just as he began to feel his grip on power slipping, that we begin to read reports of grand perorations of the King and his court around Kabul and its vicinity. ‘The wild grandeur’ of Shuja’s company ‘baffles description’, wrote the artist James Rattray when he came across them around this time. In front came the royal dromedaries ‘with bells suspended from their harness, ringing in time to their dreamy gait, with outstretched necks tasselled and ornamented. There were hundreds of them,’ and many bore small cannon decorated with green and scarlet flags which the camel drivers fired at random: ‘plumes were carried away and whiskers singed, much to the delight of the unearthly marksmen’. As the deafening camel batteries passed on, next came the royal stud, ‘glistening in cloth of gold and jewelled housings’. There followed the officers of the household,